

CSS Selectors

Learning Objectives

- Use element, class, and ID selectors to target HTML elements
- Apply attribute and pseudo-class selectors for advanced styling
- Understand selector specificity and how CSS rules are prioritized

Engage (5-7 minutes)

To paint a wall, you need to know which wall to paint. CSS selectors tell the browser exactly which HTML elements to style. Choosing the right selector is the difference between precise design and unintended changes.

Explore (10-12 minutes)

Create an HTML page with elements using different classes and IDs. Write CSS rules targeting: all p elements (element selector), elements with class="highlight" (.highlight), the element with id="main" (#main), and links on hover (a:hover). Observe which styles override others.

Explain (10-12 minutes)

Element selectors target all instances of a tag (p, h1). Class selectors target elements with a specific class attribute (.classname) – reusable across multiple elements. ID selectors target a single unique element (#idname). Attribute selectors target elements with specific attributes. Pseudo-classes like :hover, :focus, and :nth-child apply styles based on state. Specificity determines which rule wins: ID > class > element.

Elaborate (8-10 minutes)

Build a styled card component using: element selectors for base text, class selectors for card variants, ID selectors for the main card, and pseudo-classes for hover effects. Explain why specificity matters when two selectors target the same element.

Evaluate (5-8 minutes)

Write CSS selectors for: all list items, elements with class "active", the element with id "header", links visited by the user, and input fields that are focused. Rank these selectors by specificity from highest to lowest.